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When AI Takes the Lead: How AI Solicitation Shapes Users Engagement in Human-AI Collaboration

Short Paper

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Abstract

As AI agents increasingly assist humans in tasks with uncertainty and interdependence, they are evolving from passive tools into agentic collaborators to act autonomously without explicit prompting. This shift transfers traditional human-initiated collaboration into novel AI-initiated collaboration. While such solicitation facilitates task processing, it introduces a psychological trade-off between human perceived status loss and AI accountability attribution. Drawing on the functionalist perspective on team effectiveness, this study examines how AI solicitation shapes user engagement intention and explores the cognitive boundary for these opposite effects. We find that AI solicitation simultaneously enhances perceived accountability while triggering perceived status loss, yielding an overall positive effect on engagement intention. Importantly, solicitation initiated by AI is fundamentally distinct from human solicitation, and perceived human distinctiveness determines which pathway becomes dominant. These findings advance human-AI collaboration research by revealing the paradoxical mechanism underlying AI-initiated collaboration and provide actionable insights for designing agentic AI systems.

Keywords: AI solicitation, AI-initiated collaboration, Perceived accountability, Perceived status loss, Perceived human distinctiveness

Introduction

Recent advancements in artificial intelligence (AI) have enabled agents to support humans in various complex problem-solving tasks. Traditionally, such collaboration has largely relied on human-initiated interaction, in which humans direct tasks while AI agents operate as responsive copilots executing user instructions (Endsley, 2017). However, as AI agents become increasingly embedded in highly interdependent and uncertain workflows, expectations surrounding their agentic roles are evolving. Rather than remaining reactive, AI agents are increasingly expected to assume responsibility for task outcomes and act autonomously without explicit user prompting (Baird & Maruping, 2021; Stelmaszak et al., 2026).

Reflecting this trend toward more agentic AI systems, industry practices are actively developing AI systems capable of initiating collaboration and task-related interaction. For example, Meta is training AI chatbots to send unprompted messages¹, while Openclaw², an emerging agentic AI system, is designed to proactively initiate tasks, send reminders, request user input, or trigger task-related actions. These developments signal a fundamental transition from human-initiated interaction to AI-initiated collaboration, in which AI agents increasingly act as goal-directed collaborators rather than subordinate tools. We refer to one specific form of such initiated behaviors as AI solicitation, defined as an AI agent's proactive request for user input, participation, or joint coordination regarding subsequent actions within an ongoing shared task. While proactivity captures whether the AI acts in a self-starting or anticipatory manner, solicitation represents a request through which the AI seeks to involve the human collaborator and enact a coordination role. For example, an AI may proactively identify a problem and offer a suggestion; however, when the AI asks the user to proceed with the next task step together, it moves beyond offering input and begins to shape how the collaborative process is coordinated. As AI solicitation increasingly represents a plausible next generation of human-AI collaboration, an important yet unresolved question emerges: how does AI-initiated interaction influence human collaborative responses and the psychological tensions underlying human-AI teamwork?

To understand this novel AI-initiated collaboration as a dynamic team process, we draw on the functionalist perspective on team effectiveness (Wittenbaum et al., 2004), proposing that AI solicitation serves as a salient behavioral cue that elicits divergent interpretations from human collaborators. On the one hand, by proactively initiating coordination over subsequent action, AI solicitation may blur the expected boundary between AI support and human-led collaboration. Such behavior can be perceived as an illegitimate encroachment upon human authority, eliciting perceived status loss and potentially undermining user engagement. On the other hand, the same proactive solicitation may also signal the AI agent's answerability and commitment to shared task outcomes, fostering perceptions of accountability and enhancing further engagement. To better understand this psychological tension and the conditions under which human responses diverge, this study addresses the following research questions: (1) How does AI solicitation shape users' willingness to continuously engage in problem-solving contexts? (2) Through what dual psychological mechanisms does this effect emerge? And (3) under what conditions are these dual attribution pathways strengthened or weakened?

To answer these questions, we conducted two controlled online experiments to test our hypotheses. Our findings provide preliminary evidence that AI solicitation may simultaneously foster functional accountability and trigger social status concerns, with perceived human distinctiveness shaping the relative dominance of both attributional pathways. This research makes three contributions to the existing literature. First, it advances human-AI collaboration research by shifting attention from traditional human-initiated interaction to AI-initiated collaboration. Second, it extends the functionalist perspective of team effectiveness by suggesting that when the teammate is AI rather than human, proactive solicitation may generate both coordination benefits and relational tensions. Third, we identify perceived human distinctiveness as a boundary condition, illuminating the psychological heterogeneity in users' responses to agentic AI. Practically, our findings suggest that designers of agentic AI systems should calibrate proactive initiated behaviors to signal accountability while minimizing threats to human status, thereby enabling more sustainable human-AI teaming.

Theoretical Background and Hypotheses Development

The Functionalist Perspective on Team Effectiveness

To understand how agentic AI reshapes team collaboration, we draw upon the functionalist perspective on team effectiveness. The functional perspective conceptualizes team performance as emerging from interactions between structural inputs and behavioral processes that enable collective goal attainment (Wittenbaum et al., 2004). From the functionalist perspective, effective teamwork depends on interaction processes fulfilling two core functions: advancing task execution and maintaining team coordinated structure (LePINE et al., 2008; Rico et al., 2008). These functions are jointly realized through multiple categories of team processes, particularly action processes and interpersonal processes (Carter & Wynne,

¹ <https://www.engadget.com/big-tech/meta-is-reportedly-training-its-ai-chatbots-to-send-unprompted-messages-143229039.html>

² <https://openclaw.ai/>

2024; Marks et al., 2001). Action processes involve task-directed coordination activities such as monitoring progress, exchanging information, and aligning efforts, thereby directly supporting task accomplishment and enabling adaptive coordination. Interpersonal processes, in contrast, regulate relational dynamics and sustain social stability, which facilitates continued coordination and indirectly supports effective task execution over time. Because agentic AI can now initiate interactions rather than merely respond to human commands, its behaviors may influence both functional dimensions during team collaboration.

Both action and interpersonal processes are embedded within team hierarchy, defined as vertical differentiation among members in access to socially valued resources, including status, authority, and expertise (Harrison & Klein, 2007; Hays & Bendersky, 2015). From a functionalist viewpoint, hierarchy facilitates coordination in both process by clarifying roles, guiding resource allocation, and establishing legitimate patterns of interaction (Anderson & Brown, 2010; Biggart & Hamilton, 1984). Clear hierarchical structures reduce uncertainty, provide psychological stability, and facilitate decision-making, thereby supporting team viability (Galinsky & Chou, 2011; Tiedens & Fragale, 2003). However, introducing an agentic AI teammate may blur these established structures: while proactive AI behaviors can enhance coordination, they may also challenge traditional assumptions about human authority and role centrality within teams.

To link these team-level dynamics with individual responses, we draw on “computer as social actor” (CASA) paradigm and attribution theory (Heider, 2013; Nass et al., 1994). When human collaborators encounter unprompted proactive behaviors from agentic AI teammates, they engage in sensemaking processes to infer whether such actions support or disrupt ongoing collaboration. Because proactive initiatives directly intervene in coordination process, they can be interpreted through the two functional lenses of teamwork identified above. On one hand, proactive AI behavior may be viewed as facilitating action processes by helping the team manage uncertainty and advance task execution. On the other hand, the same behavior may be interpreted as interfering with interpersonal processes by challenging established expectations regarding roles, authority, and interaction norms. These divergent interpretations provide a theoretical foundation for understanding how identical actions can produce contrasting collaborative consequences.

AI Solicitation and User Engagement

We define AI solicitation as a proactive behavior in which an AI teammates explicitly initiate collaboration with other team members (i.e., joint decision-making or coordinated action) to reduce task uncertainty and advance ongoing task execution. In traditional human teams, employees frequently solicit information, advice, or assistance to better understand their environment and coordinate collective work (Ashford et al., 2003; Lim et al., 2020). Within current human–AI teaming, where humans and AI agents jointly generate solutions, solicitation serves an important function by achieving shared goals and facilitating coordination.

From a functional perspective on teamwork, this solicitation is generally expected to elicit positive collaborative responses. When members proactively solicit resources or collaboration toward collective goals, the behavior serves a critical function: it explicitly identifies information gaps and clarifies immediate next steps. By establishing a clear focal point for joint effort, solicitation eliminates the uncertainty and cognitive friction typically associated with coordinating interdependent tasks. Consequently, members experience smoother interactions and are more willing to engage in such collaboration. However, the effectiveness of solicitation may depend on agent identity. Prior research suggests that responses to others’ requests are shaped not only by task considerations but also by relational expectations between interaction partners. In interpersonal settings, response to others’ requests is influenced by perceived social bonds, reciprocal obligations, and affective attachment embedded in social exchange relationships (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). As AI teammates differ fundamentally from human teammates in forming social relationships and reciprocal obligations, identical solicitation behaviors may evoke weaker relational responses, thereby attenuating their positive influence on further user engagement. We therefore expect agent identity to moderate the effectiveness of solicitation:

Hypothesis 1 (H1): The positive effect of solicitation on user engagement intention is weaker when the teammate is an AI agent rather than a human agent.

AI Solicitation and its Dual Path Impacts on User Engagement

In traditional socio-technical systems, humans occupy a clearly dominant position, while AI functions as a subordinate tool operating within a human-centric hierarchy. In contemporary human–AI collaboration, however, agentic AI is functioning as a teammate and dynamically coordinating with human partners (Schuetz & Venkatesh, 2020). Despite this characterization of teammates, AI and human members still remain fundamentally distinct in their hierarchical standing. First, although AI agents increasingly demonstrate decision-making capabilities, humans retain ultimate authority and remain “in the loop” as final supervisors (Lou et al., 2025). Second, AI agents cannot be held accountable for their actions, creating asymmetries between decision authority and responsibility attribution (Gabriel et al., 2024). Third, while AI may match or exceed humans in analytical performance, it lacks emotional intelligence and social relationships that confer interpersonal influence in a team (Dennis et al., 2023; Matziou et al., 2026). In social groups, status refers to the respect, influence, and authority associated with an individual’s position within the group (Anderson & Berdahl, 2002). Thus, these differences still position AI teammates at a lower status relative to humans.

Compared with reactive AI, which identifies a task issue and provides task-relevant advice, AI solicitation introduces a different form of role enactment. By explicitly inviting the human to jointly move the next step forward, the AI not only contributes useful information but also initiates coordination over the action process. This shift matters because, as discussed above, human–AI teams are still embedded in an asymmetric hierarchy in which humans retain ultimate authority and role centrality. When a lower-status AI agent proactively initiates joint action, its behavior may therefore be negatively interpreted as crossing the expected boundary between providing support and directing collaboration. Such boundary crossing can make human collaborators feel that their exclusive authority to structure the task process is being weakened, thereby increasing perceived status loss. This perceived status loss may evoke defensive reactions toward the AI agent and reduce users’ willingness to continue engaging in future collaboration.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Perceived status loss negatively mediates the relationship between AI solicitation and user engagement intention.

AI solicitation may also trigger a positive functional attribution by enhancing perceived accountability of the AI agent. Perceived accountability refers to users’ subjective perception that the AI agent is answerable for its actions and committed to the shared task outcome (Hall et al., 2017; Wallace et al., 2011). In this context, perceived accountability is conceptualized as team members’ shared expectations of being held answerable for their actions or decisions (Stewart et al., 2023). In interdependent teams, accountability emerges through interaction patterns and shared expectations regarding responsibility for collective outcomes (Kou & Stewart, 2018).

Compared with a suggestion-only baseline, in which the AI provides task-relevant advice while leaving subsequent action to the human, AI solicitation can be interpreted as a stronger intention to take accountability. By proactively inviting the human to jointly move the next step forward, the AI indicates not only task competence but also willingness to participate in coordinating the action process. Such solicitation makes users more likely to attribute psychological ownership and answerability to the AI agent (Pierce et al., 2001), perceiving it as sharing responsibility for the collaborative process rather than merely supplying information. This heightened perceived accountability can promote user engagement intention. In interdependent collaboration, users’ willingness to remain engaged depends not only on the perceived usefulness of a teammate’s input, but also on whether the teammate is perceived as a dependable contributor to the joint task process. When users perceive the AI agent as accountable, they are more likely to believe that it will coordinate its actions around shared goals, monitor the implications of its suggestions, and contribute to collective outcomes rather than merely provide isolated recommendations. Such perceptions make continued collaboration with the AI agent feel more reliable and worthwhile. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 3 (H3): Perceived accountability of the AI agent positively mediates the relationship between AI solicitation and user engagement intention.

The Moderating Role of Perceived Human Distinctiveness

Although AI solicitation activates dual attribution pathways, the relative dominance of each pathway depends on individuals' cognitive orientations toward the human–AI boundary. We focus on perceived human distinctiveness as a critical moderator because it captures the extent to which individuals believe humans possess unique and irreplaceable qualities that distinguish them from artificial entities, including moral responsibility, tacit insight, and social connection. According to social identity theory, comparisons with similar outgroups can induce threats to ingroup distinctiveness (Cha et al., 2020). In the context of human–AI teaming, this belief is especially relevant because agentic AI increasingly performs roles that were traditionally reserved for humans, such as initiating interaction, coordinating action, and shaping team processes. Thus, perceived human distinctiveness directly concerns the categorical boundary between humans and AI and the legitimacy of their relative positions within the team hierarchy.

This boundary-oriented belief makes perceived human distinctiveness particularly relevant for understanding responses to AI solicitation. Unlike evaluations that focus on whether AI is capable, trustworthy, or humanlike, perceived human distinctiveness reflects whether individuals view AI's entry into human-like agentic roles as appropriate and legitimate. Individuals with higher human distinctiveness maintain stricter categorical boundaries between humans and AI and are more likely to regard humans as occupying a naturally superior position in collaborative settings. When an AI teammate proactively initiates interaction and solicits joint action, these individuals may interpret the behavior as crossing the expected boundary between artificial support and human-led coordination. As a result, AI solicitation is less likely to be attributed to genuine accountability for shared outcomes and more likely to be perceived as an inappropriate intrusion into human authority, thereby amplifying perceived status loss.

Conversely, individuals with lower perceived human distinctiveness maintain more flexible boundaries between humans and AI. They are less likely to assume that collaborative authority and coordination legitimacy should be reserved exclusively for humans. Accordingly, they may evaluate AI solicitation more through its functional contribution to task execution than through its implications for human–AI categorical hierarchy. For these individuals, AI solicitation is more likely to be interpreted as a legitimate coordination effort that signals accountability and supports task effectiveness, while concerns over hierarchical disruption become less salient.

Hypothesis 4 (H4): Perceived human distinctiveness positively moderates the relationship between AI solicitation and perceived status loss, therefore strengthen the negative effect of AI solicitation on user engagement intention.

Hypothesis 5 (H5): Perceived human distinctiveness negatively moderates the relationship between AI solicitation and perceived accountability, therefore weaken the positive effect of AI solicitation on user engagement intention.

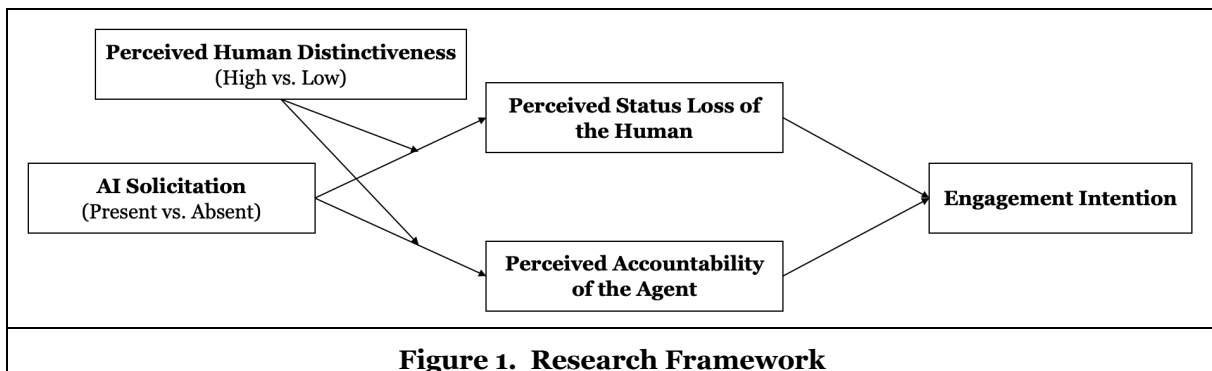


Figure 1. Research Framework

Study 1

Experimental Design

To provide a preliminary controlled test of whether AI solicitation differs from human solicitation, we conducted a 2 (identity: human agent vs. AI agent) $\times$ 2 (solicitation: present vs. absent) between-subjects

experiment in an online collaborative context. We adopted a collaborative house-building task in Minecraft, which involved constructing the main structure of a house, decorating its exterior, and optimizing functional details. This task created multiple opportunities for participants to coordinate with a teammate, evaluate task-related suggestions, and decide how to proceed in an interdependent problem-solving process. To ensure experimental control, the collaborative process was presented through pre-recorded videos, which allowed all participants to experience the same task progression, teammate behavior, and solicitation timing. To enhance immersion and reduce passive observation, the video included active interaction points: after the teammate either solicited collaboration or provided a suggestion, the video paused and participants were required to indicate how they would proceed before the subsequent content continued.

To manipulate agent identity, participants were randomly presented with a teammate's self-introduction: "Hi, I am your AI teammate Gray. Now, let's build a lovely house together!" in the AI condition, or "Hi, I am your teammate Gray. Now, let's build a lovely house together!" in the human condition. Throughout the task scenario, the teammate was consistently labeled as either an AI teammate or a human teammate, allowing participants to clearly identify the teammate's agent identity during the collaboration.

We manipulated solicitation based on the same next-step problem, adjusting torch placement to improve exterior lighting distribution. The difference was designed to capture the AI's initiation behavior rather than the substantive content of its advice. In the solicitation condition, the teammate explicitly initiated joint action by stating: "To ensure the exterior lighting distribution meets the requirements, we need to adjust the torch placement. I'd like to start planning the adjustment together with you." In the no-solicitation condition, the teammate was designed as a reactive information provider that only offered a suggestion while leaving the next action decision to the human: "To ensure the exterior lighting distribution meets the requirements, I suggest considering adjusting the torch placement, which perhaps requires further planning." After completing the scenario, participants filled out questionnaires reporting their subjective perceptions and demographic information. The manipulation check for solicitation was measured immediately after the collaborative task and before the dependent variable using a single item on a seven-point Likert scale: "In this task, to what extent do you agree that this teammate invited you to collaborate to move the next step forward, rather than merely offering a suggestion or prediction?" Participants' engagement intention for further collaboration was measured using three items adapted from Mütterlein et al. (2018). We also measure perceived agreeableness using four items adapted from Wiggins et al. (1988). All items were assessed on a seven-point Likert-type scale.

Results

We collected 217 valid responses after excluding participants who failed the attention checks. No significant differences across experimental conditions in participants' demographic characteristics (i.e., gender and age) or prior familiarity with AI agents and Minecraft. All participants correctly identified their teammates as human or AI. Independent-samples t-tests confirmed that participants in the solicitation condition were significantly more likely to perceive the teammate as inviting them to move the next step forward than those in the no-solicitation condition ($M = 5.83$ vs. 4.86 , $SD = 0.93$ vs. 1.39 , $t = 6.05$, $p < 0.001$). In addition, we find no significant difference in perceived agreeableness of the tone in solicitation between the solicitation and no-solicitation conditions ($M = 5.36$ vs. 5.19 , $p = 0.14$), suggesting that the manipulation did not simply vary the teammate's interpersonal warmth.

The two-way ANOVA revealed a significant interaction effect on further engagement intention ($F(1, 213) = 4.557$, $p = 0.034$). When collaborating with a human agent, participants reported higher engagement intention when the agent solicited their goal-oriented collaboration ($M = 5.95$, $SD = 0.09$; $F(1, 213) = 28.11$, $p < 0.001$) than when it did not ($M = 5.31$, $SD = 0.09$). When collaborating with an AI agent, participants also reported higher engagement intention when the agent solicited their goal-oriented ($M = 5.90$, $SD = 0.08$; $F(1, 213) = 6.52$, $p = 0.011$) than when it did not ($M = 5.62$, $SD = 0.08$). We further employed PROCESS Model 1 with 5,000 bootstrap iterations at a 95% confidence interval to conduct moderation analyses (Hayes, 2017). The model included solicitation (1 = present, 0 = absent) as the independent variable, further engagement intention as the dependent variable, and agent identity (1 = AI, 0 = human) as the moderator. The results revealed that the identity of AI agents negatively moderated the effect of solicitation on further engagement intention ($\beta = -0.352$, $SE = 0.165$, $t = -2.14$, $p = 0.034$). These findings provide a human baseline demonstrating that solicitation generally enhances user engagement intention,

while users interpret AI-initiated solicitation through different mechanisms from those in interpersonal interaction. Therefore, H1 was supported.

Study 2

Experimental Design

We further examined the psychological mechanisms underlying AI solicitation using the same Minecraft-based collaborative scenario and solicitation manipulation as in Study 1. Because Study 2 focused on the dual pathways triggered by AI-initiated collaboration, all participants were informed that they had an AI teammate, and solicitation was manipulated as a single between-subjects factor. This design allowed us to examine whether AI solicitation increased engagement intention through perceived accountability and perceived status loss under the controlled paradigm established in Study 1. In addition to participants' intention on further collaboration, we measured perceived accountability of the agent (Adam, 2022; Vance et al., 2015), perceived status loss (SimanTov-Nachlieli, 2024), and perceived human distinctiveness (Cha et al., 2020). All items were assessed on a seven-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree.

Results

We collected 113 valid responses from a separate participant sample after excluding participants who failed the attention checks. Randomization checks showed no significant differences between the solicitation and no-solicitation conditions in participants' demographic characteristics or prior familiarity with AI agents and Minecraft, suggesting that these background variables were unlikely to confound the observed effects. Independent-samples t-tests confirmed that participants in the solicitation condition perceived the AI agent as inviting them to move the next step forward more strongly than those in the no-solicitation condition ($M = 5.79$ vs. 4.72 , $SD = 0.91$ vs. 1.52 , $t = 4.53$, $p < 0.001$). One-way ANOVA revealed that participants in the solicitation condition reported higher engagement intention than those in the no-solicitation condition ($M = 5.92$ vs. 5.62 , $SD = 0.59$ vs. 0.58 , $F(1, 111) = 7.68$, $p = 0.007$). They also reported higher perceived status loss ($M = 3.55$ vs. 3.18 , $SD = 1.13$ vs. 0.77 , $F(1, 111) = 4.15$, $p = 0.044$) and higher perceived accountability of the AI agent ($M = 5.56$ vs. 5.21 , $SD = 0.62$ vs. 0.61 , $F(1, 111) = 9.12$, $p = 0.003$).

Table 1. The Moderated Mediation Analysis						
	Effect	SE	t-value	p-value	LLCI	ULCI
Direct Effect	0.240	0.099	2.419	0.017	0.043	0.437
Indirect Effect of Perceived Status Loss						
Higher human distinctiveness	-0.148	0.055	—	—	-0.270	-0.052
Lower human distinctiveness	0.009	0.041	—	—	-0.068	0.102
Index of Moderated Mediation	-0.069	0.031	—	—	-0.139	-0.018
Indirect Effect of Perceived Accountability						
Higher human distinctiveness	0.042	0.061	—	—	-0.071	0.173
Lower human distinctiveness	0.205	0.074	—	—	0.078	0.365
Index of Moderated Mediation	-0.072	0.039	—	—	-0.157	-0.003

We further conducted mediation and moderated mediation analysis using SPSS Process Model 4 and Model 7. First, the results of mediation analysis revealed a positive effect of AI solicitation on perceived status loss of human ($\beta = 0.369$, $SE = 0.181$, $t = 2.036$, $p = 0.044$) and a negative effect of perceived status loss on user engagement intention ($\beta = -0.178$, $SE = 0.050$, $t = -3.561$, $p = 0.001$). Additionally, the result showed a positive effect of AI solicitation on perceived accountability of the agent ($\beta = 0.350$, $SE = 0.116$, $t = 3.02$, $p = 0.003$) and a positive effect of perceived accountability on user engagement intention ($\beta = 0.367$, $SE = 0.078$, $t = 4.678$, $p < 0.001$). The indirect effects through perceived status loss ($\beta = -0.066$, $SE = 0.038$, 95% CI = $[-0.150, -0.001]$) and perceived accountability ($\beta = 0.128$, $SE = 0.056$, 95% CI = $[0.037, 0.255]$) were both significant. Therefore, H2 and H3 were both supported. Second, there was a significant positive

interaction effect between AI solicitation and perceived human distinctiveness on perceived status loss ($\beta = 0.388$, $SE = 0.140$, $t = 2.779$, $p = 0.006$), and a significant negative interaction effect between AI solicitation and perceived human distinctiveness on perceived accountability ($\beta = -0.196$, $SE = 0.092$, $t = -2.127$, $p = 0.036$). Furthermore, the moderated mediation analysis revealed a significant index of moderated mediation for the indirect effect of AI solicitation on engagement intention via perceived status loss (index = -0.069 , $SE = 0.032$, 95% CI = $[-0.141, -0.017]$) as well as for the indirect effect via perceived accountability (index = -0.072 , $SE = 0.039$, 95% CI = $[-0.156, -0.004]$). These findings provide evidence that perceived human distinctiveness conditioned the two psychological pathways of AI solicitation. Specifically, higher human distinctiveness strengthened the negative indirect effect through perceived status loss while weakening the positive indirect effect through perceived accountability. Therefore, H4 and H5 were supported.

Conclusion and Discussion

In conclusion, this research provides preliminary evidence on the effects of AI solicitation in contemporary human–AI teaming through two controlled online experiments. Our findings suggest that proactive solicitation can enhance users' intention to engage in further collaboration, but this positive effect appears weaker when the solicitor is an AI rather than a human teammate. The results are also consistent with a dual-pathway account: AI solicitation may foster engagement by increasing perceived accountability of the AI agent, while also reducing engagement by increasing humans' perceived status loss. Moreover, perceived human distinctiveness appears to shape the relative strength of these two pathways, amplifying the status-loss pathway while weakening the accountability pathway. These findings contribute to human–AI teaming research by shifting attention from human-initiated AI use to AI-initiated collaboration, and by showing that agentic AI behaviors may simultaneously support coordination and create relational tensions. Practically, the findings suggest that designers of agentic AI systems should calibrate AI-initiated behaviors to signal accountability for shared outcomes while avoiding unnecessary threats to users' perceived authority and role centrality.

However, several limitations should be noted. First, both studies used pre-recorded videos to ensure experimental control and identical task progression across participants. Although active interaction points were included to enhance immersion, this design limits the realism and ecological validity of the collaborative experience. Second, the agent identity manipulation and solicitation manipulation may not fully capture how agent identity shapes responses and how authentic solicitation behavior happens in realistic human–AI collaboration settings. Future research should conduct additional experiments in more ecologically valid settings, such as real-time interaction with adaptive AI agents and collaboration tasks with higher interdependence or practical consequences, to further examine the construct validity, boundary conditions, and generalizability of AI solicitation.

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